

any media, export and import can only be done from the MS Access database management application.

Another feature we checked out was whether the application allows viewing a screen in full-screen mode. We found that Tally, Simply Accounting and Arthalekha had the option of being viewed on the full screen, whereas the others were limited to being viewed only in the default size specified by the application.

Arthalekha has the distinction of being completely multi-lingual. At the main menu itself, there is a toggle button that allows you to switch between Hindi and English. While Wings Pro also provides multi-lingual support, it does so at the report level and not at the menu level.

Value for money

While price is undoubtedly an important factor, it should not take precedence over the quality of the software. So the key is to keep the price factor at the back of your mind and first look out for features you need. Ask yourself what you want out of the financial accounting software. Is it just the usual ledger journal and voucher entries that need to be taken care of? Or do you want advanced features such as inventory control, MIS, multi-user password facilities, etc? There is no point in

shelling out all that extra money for a leading software if you'll never use half of its hi-fi features. So first identify the software that fulfils your needs, and then see if the price tag is justified.

Of the software we tested, Wings2000 is absolutely free and it provides some really decent features that would satisfy

most home users. But when it comes to advanced features, it falls flat and that's where software like Tally, FACT and Simply Accounting score.

If you have a low-end machine such as a 486, a DOS-based program is the way to go. While ACE and Easy Accounting provide features such as graphical representation of your data and password facility, their prices are a bit steep.

And although your journal, ledger, bank and cash details are all looked after, you might still miss the GUI that you've become used to with Windows.

Account21 would suit a small businessperson, with features such as multi-currency, reminder letters to debtors and good security options, although you would have to pay more for a multi-user version.

Wings2000 Pro, FACT, Tally, and EX Next Generation, all fall in the small-to-medium office segment. Apart from the

regular features, they also incorporate other features that a mid-sized business would require. Features such as an excellent graphical user interface, MIS reporting facility and multi-user facility makes them complete financial accounting packages.

Security

We are all extremely cautious about who should know how much about our monetary transactions. For a businessman, it is extremely necessary to have total control over how he wants his accounts to be handled. Many financial accounting packages allow you to hide or completely disable certain features depending on who is using the package. You can create multiple users, and define rights regarding which features they can use.

Besides multi-user security, encryption is another way to keep your data safe. We gave higher scores to software that support data encryption and multiple users.

Simply Accounting, FACT, Arthalekha and Accounting21 provide intensive security features. However, they have an open database format, which means that files created are not saved in the encrypted format. Tally was the only one that provided encryption support.

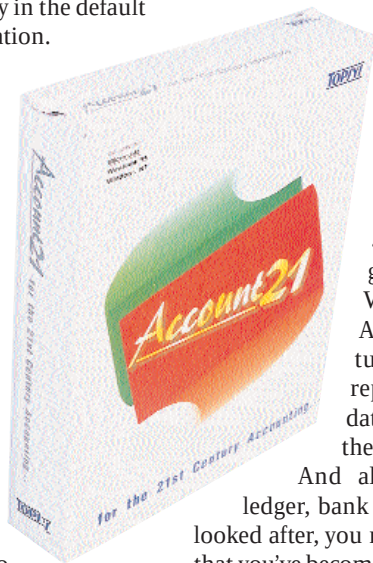
EX, which uses the MS Access database, provides almost no security for the database, but it has multi-user security wherein certain features can be disabled for a particular user. Tally, FACT, Wings2000 Pro, Simply Accounting and Account21 also provided multi-user accounting features, whereas DOS-based programs like ACE and Easy Accounting only provided the usual single-user password facility.

Help and Documentation

Help and documentation comes in various forms and media—from manuals to PDF and HTML files. The aim of help files and documentation is to get the user to learn and gain expertise of the software in the shortest time possible.

Tally EIS 5.4 has a really interesting manual. The manual has a lot of screenshots of the screens that you would come across while working on Tally.

It is well-categorised with the tasks arranged in appropriate groupings. There are sets of instructions on how to do particular tasks. The quality and quantity of help given allows a new user to do exactly what he needs by just



Curb Piracy! Go for Free Software

One key factor that most people tend to ignore is to install an original licensed copy of the software. It is a misconception that is propagated by local vendors who blatantly say, "Tell us which software you want, we'll install it for you."

All software has to be purchased and nothing comes free of charge. Even the most popular of all operating system software—MS Windows—has to be bought.

Pirated software is a major reason for the malfunctioning of the software, leading it to crash frequently, and it is you who have to suffer in the end. So installing a cheap and pirated version of the software is not exactly the right move if you want to have a trouble-free and stable working experience. More-

over, many companies provide free updates, excellent after-sales services and lumpsum discounts on forthcoming products to bonafide registered customers. And then there's the small matter of piracy being illegal. Does it still sound like a waste of money to buy original software?

If you would still rather not spend the money, you can go in for free accounting packages such as Wings. A professional version of the package is also available, which you can purchase if you are satisfied with its working and require advanced user options. Many open source packages are also available. Accounting applications come built into Linux and its other variants.